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CHAPTER FOURTEEN

FROM OGHUZ KHAN TO EXODUS
LINEAGE, HEROISM, AND MIGRATION IN OGHUZ TURK TRADITION

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The epic history of the Oghuz Turks[1] is typically portrayed by scholars as consisting of two ambiguously related cycles: the story of the mythical ruler Oghuz Khan[2] and *The Book of Dede Korkut*. (This vagueness is largely due to the fact that both traditions bear the title *Oghūznāme* or "The Book of Oghuz.") These two components of the tradition have regularly been viewed through distinct "civilizational" lenses, though, and have seldom been convincingly brought together in a comprehensive historical or cultural framework. Most scholars who study Turkish epics seek to distill a native national spirit from the supposedly alien elements of Persian and Arab civilizations, usually understood as Islamic and urban and thus deeply inimical to Turkish culture.[3] This approach has often led to a disproportionate focus on the purportedly less Islamic *Book of Dede Korkut* as the primary text of Oghuz epic and thus a particularly faithful rendering of tribal Turkish culture.

This chapter offers a fresh framework for Oghuz popular traditions and historical consciousness by focusing on the continuity between these two cycles and also suggesting that a third set of narratives, concerning the trans-Eurasian westward migrations of the Oghuz from roughly 1000 to 1400, should be understood as a concluding episode of Oghuz history. Although not circulating in epic form, this thread, or rather final episode, was transmitted over the centuries in sketchy fragments and recounted a violent westward exodus out of Inner Asia prompted chiefly by the Mongols in the thirteenth century. This study offers an overview of three phases of the epic's development, giving special attention to the overlooked migration narrative, and shows how the epic flourished in each phase according to particular historical circumstances.[4]

OGHUZ KHAN AND HINTS OF AN EPIC TRADITION

The legend begins with Oghuz, the common ancestor of all Turks and Mongols who lived several thousand years before the time of the Prophet Muhammad. He was a descendent of Japheth, the son of Noah who had inherited the lands of

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Central Asia (typically *torkestān* in the Persian of the early texts). A child of prodigious strength and skill, Oghuz was born Muslim in a society of unbelievers. In a dream, the newborn told his mother that he would refuse her milk unless she accepted his faith, to which she acquiesced. He gave himself the name Oghuz and grew into a great warrior, later demanding that his wife embrace Islam as well. When she refused, he married another woman, and then another, until the third finally accepted his religion. Oghuz's father, Qara Khan, was angered by his son's apostasy and gathered his relatives to avenge this betrayal. Oghuz and his followers emerged victorious from the ensuing clash after killing Qara Khan and his lot, while some of those defeated retreated eastward and would become the ancestors of the Mongols. Subsequently, Oghuz became *Khan*, embarking on a vast campaign of world conquest and domination.

This account depicts an ancient pre-Islamic setting in the Inner Asian steppe, but evidence for the tradition's popularity only surfaces when it was circulating as an Islamization story in the Mongol period. The above version was elaborated by the minister of the Mongol Ilkhanid Empire in Iran (1256–1335), Rashid al-Din Fazlollah Hamadani (died 1318), in the beginning of his immense Persian-language *Jāmeʿ ol-tavārīkh* (The culmination of chronicles) and constitutes the earliest dated and longest text in the Oghuz Khan corpus. This story demonstrates the shared origins of the Mongols and the Turks and gives them a common Muslim ancestor, an important priority for the newly Islamized Mongol ruling class. Soon after, another Mongol historian, Hamdollah Mostowfi, penned a shorter version of the same story in his *Tārīkh-e gozideh* (1330).

In the post-Mongol era, the narrative was widely adopted by Turkic dynasties in an effort to claim a noble lineage linked to Abrahamic figures, as well as a legacy of world conquest and dominion. An important update to the story took place in the court of the Timurid Empire, which reigned over much of Iran and Central Asia in the fifteenth century. In the 1420s, Sharaf al-Din 'Ali Yazdi wrote his *Ẓafarnāmeh* (also spelled "*Zafarnāma*"), in which he revised the details and chronology of the Oghuz Khan legend. His approach became the dominant model across the Persianate world, including in the Ottoman, Aq Qoyunlu, Safavid, and Shaybanid states. For instance, it served as the key source for the story in one of the most widely copied Persian histories, Mirkhvand's *Rawżat al-safā* (The Garden of Purity, 1497). Rashid al-Din's seminal formulation also continued to be copied in Anatolia, Iran, and Central Asia over the following centuries.[5]

Although its religious and political message surely suited the needs of the Mongol elite, the emergence of this tradition in the Mongol era cannot be principally attributed to political motives. For the Persian-speaking historians of Ilkhanid realms, the account was one component of a profound intellectual effort to understand the arrival of the Mongols as a part of a larger "Turk" phenomenon: Rashid al-Din began his chronicle with the rather urgent update that the

> Peoples that are known as 'Turk'...have scattered by means of invasion in all of the lands of China, India, Kashmir, Iran, Rome, and the Levant in strength, glory, and dominion and have taken control of most of the countries in the settled parts of the earth.
>
> (1995, 40)

What follows are several hundred pages ambitiously attempting to systematically classify all the Turco-Mongol peoples of the steppe.

The evidence indicates that Mongol historians drew upon an active epic tradition. The hundreds of names and vignettes in Rashid al-Din's account concerning Oghuz Khan's conquests and progeny are too detailed to suggest anything but an extensive base of well-elaborated written and oral sources. This author notes that no comprehensive book of Turkish or Mongol origins has been drawn up and that he obtained much of his information from "esteemed storytellers and transmitters" (1995, 41). Meanwhile, his contemporary from Mamluk Egypt, Ibn al-Dawadari (died after 1336), describes in one of his chronicles how Oghuz lore is preserved by Turks who play a popular stringed instrument called the *qopuz* (1990, 55). Mostowfi also evokes an oral tradition by adjusting the names according to the accounts he heard, for instance, modifying *Dīp Yāqūī* to *Dīb Bāqū* (1983, 562), and by adding entirely new elements to the story (1983, 563).

Two other early texts also evoke a tradition spanning well beyond the Mongol court; one is a twenty-one-folio fragment of Uyghur-script verse containing a pre-Islamic version of the Oghuz Khan tale located in the Bibliotèque Nationale of France ("Le livre d'Oughouz," supplement turc 1001), and the other, the so-called Uzunköprü *Oghūznāme*, four folios of *masnavi* verse in eastern Turkic from a now lost anthology last known to have been consulted in Turkey in the 1930s (Orkun 1935). Their linguistic character and the use of Uyghur script in the former have led some scholars to believe that these two fragments originated in Ilkhanid realms (Sümer 1967, 364; Binbaş 2010), although it is difficult to pin down the origins of the Uyghur-script fragment beyond a general fourteenth- or fifteenth-century Mongol-Çağatay linguistic context (Ağca 2016, 61). We can add to these an early fourteenth-century collection of proverbs from the lands of Golden Horde bearing the title "*The Words of the Oghūznāme, known as the Ancestral Proverbs,*" referencing the "prophetic" figure of "Oghūz Ātā" as described by Evrim Binbaş (2010). Studying similar traditions in the former lands of the Golden Horde, Devin DeWeese (1994, 501–2) also concludes that tales of Oghuz Khan emerged in an Islamizing framework independent of Rashid al-Din's account. The prominent role of poetry in the early texts and the key components of heroic conquest and etiology conform to the features of a classic epic tradition.

After the Mongol era, however, there is little evidence to suggest that the tradition continued to circulate orally save for certain areas of Inner Asia and Iran (Karamustafa 2022, 7–12). It instead came to feature as a historical note in Persianate historiography, where it was integrated into an expanding and inclusive Iranian legendary framework. It is well known that the tenth to twelfth centuries witnessed the growth of the *Shāhnāmeh* (also spelled "*Shāhnāma*"; The Book of Kings) tradition in new Persian through both the seminal text of the Ghaznavid poet Ferdowsi (also spelled "Firdausi"; died circa 1020) and a range of spin-off traditions sometimes called the Sistan epic cycles from the eleventh century onward. Although this trend was a continuation of pre-Islamic Iranian oral tradition, it took place under the aegis of Eurasia's Turkish elite that came to power after the year 1000.

As *Shāhnāmeh*-writing expanded under Mongol rulers in Iran (Sims 2006, 269), the periodization, characters, and storylines from the epic also came to be incorporated into other storytelling traditions (Rubanovich 2012, 33) and

historiographical works (Melville 2012, 193–94). This trend spread far to the west; the Armenians of fourteenth-century Erzincan (today a city in eastern Turkey) yearned for a *Shāhnāmeh*-style epic poem in their language (Pifer 2021, 171), and the fifteenth-century Ottoman court institutionalized the office of the *şehnāmecī* (Turkish, "*Shāhnāmeh* writer") to render the exploits of the sultan in heroic Persian verse. What was at stake went beyond literary form and entailed the adoption of Iranian epic time on par with "Islamic religious time" (Bashir 2014, 534).

Oghuz Khan came to be integrated into this Iranian framework. Rashid al-Din opens his history of the Turks by comparing those vanquished by the Mongols to the cruel king Zahhak of Persian legend (1995, 32). Mostowfi strengthened these parallels, portraying the Oghuz Turks as the Turanian antagonists of the Iranian epic:

> The kingship of the line of Japheth son of Noah remained among the progeny of Oghuz for nearly one thousand years. In the time of Fereydun,[6] his son Tur fought a great battle with them [the descendants of Oghuz], and nobody was spared.
>
> (1983, 562)

The same author also remarks that "Some consider Oghuz Khan to be Afrasiyab, but there is no basis for this," referring to the legendary king of Turan and the main antagonist of the *Shāhnāmeh* (1983, 562). Such parallelisms were not new; Afrasiyab in particular had been likened or equated with many Turkish rulers already in the pre-Mongol era.[7]

Yazdi's *Ẓafarnāmeh* takes the parallels in a more complimentary direction:

> It is said that the son of Japheth was a contemporary of Keyūmarṯ. He is the first of the Turkish kings and Keyūmarṯ the first of the Iranian kings, and he discharged the practice of *khān*-ship and the custom of the guardianship of the world in Turkistan.
>
> (Yazdi 2009, 44)

Yazdi explicitly equates legendary Turkish and Iranian kingship, an approach he replicates when noting that "Oghuz Khan was among the Turkish kings as Jamshīd was among the Iranian kings," abandoning Mostowfi's comparison to Afrasiyab for a more flattering association with the Iranian hero (2009, 49). We even see Ferdowsi-style couplets in Yazdi's description of Oghuz Khan's exploits:

> Together they arrived at the hunting field / no choice left for Oghuz but battle.
> The two armies clashed in such a way / that from iron sprang forth flame.
>
> (2009, 49)

This was the comprehensive incorporation of Oghuz Khan into the *Shāhnāmeh* tradition.[8] Given how one seventeenth-century writer from Khwarizm portrays *Shāhnāmeh*-oriented claims of descent among the Turkish Seljuqs as a form of arrogance, this development could be interpreted as a de-popularization of the Oghuz Khan tradition (Abu'l-Ghazi 1996, 206). He remained important as an ancestor conferring political legitimacy and a noble lineage linked to ancient Abrahamic and

Iranian figures, but with a diminished relevance in the oral realm. Although the movement of Oghuz pride among the elites of the Kara Koyunlu, Aq Qoyunlu, and Ottoman dynasties of the fifteenth century continued to pay a cursory homage to Oghuz Khan in their court chronicles (Flemming 2018, 228), by this time Oghuz had become an ancestral figure whose story was no longer related in any great detail.

THE DEDE KORKUT CYCLE

The next phase in the Oghuz epic's development is encompassed in *The Book of Dede Korkut*, a literary tradition that left behind the ancient pre-Islamic past and took up the early Islamic period. This is a prosimetric epic cycle recounting the exploits of the Oghuz tribe (divided into the factions of the Inner and Outer Oghuz) and their clashes with the infidel on the ambiguously located frontiers of the Islamic world. These stories belonged to a tradition of popular performance, which circulated from the fourteenth to at least the sixteenth centuries in the lands of Anatolia, Iran, and parts of Inner Asia.

Dede Korkut is a charismatic wise man who councils the Oghuz nation and recounts their exploits, while their sovereign is the great Bayandur Khan, the "Khan of Khans."[9] Rather than the themes of lineage, etiology, and world conquest, which characterize the Oghuz Khan narratives, the tales of Dede Korkut recount problems of heroism, kinship, and marriage within the community of the Oghuz. Valor in this epic tradition is linked to the key frontier values of raiding and fighting the infidel. For instance, the inexperienced Uruz makes the following complaint to his father, Kazan Beg, in one of the cycle's coming-of-age tales: "When have you ever taken me to the infidel frontier, swung your sword, and cut heads?" (Tezcan and Boeschoten 2018, 98). Recurring, too, are taunts to the infidel uttered in rhyme:

> Why do you praise your spear, cursed infidel? / It is no match for my shepherd's crook.
>
> Why do you praise your arrows, infidel dog? / It is no match for my hazel slingshot!
>
> (2018, 245)

These Oghuz exploits held great popular appeal in the post-Mongol era. The warrior ethos of the epic evokes the values of holy war, which permeated the political discourses of the states that formed along the former Byzantine frontier in the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries (Darling 2000). All the same, the tradition was not referenced in court histories from the period and apparently had limited appeal among the political elites. John Woods has obliquely linked *The Book of Dede Korkut* to the politics of the Aq Qoyunlu dynasty (1378–1501) and its claim to rule by dint of its descent from Bayandur Khan. Woods has demonstrated how echoes of the epic cycle and the dynasty's ideology can be discerned in elite Aq Qoyunlu and pro-Aq Qoyunlu Ottoman sources, despite their authors' outward preference for an Oghuz Khan-oriented genealogy (1999, 177–78). The likely sixteenth-century date of writing of the tradition's two longest manuscripts shows how it continued to circulate well after the Aq Qoyunlu period, as does evidence referencing the tradition from Ottoman sources from the period (Sümer 1967, 368–70, 409).

The Dede Korkut tradition has been subject to the prevailing civilizational logic of the fields of Turkish and Islamic studies, which has emphasized the cycle's supposedly "pre-Islamic" Turkish character by dint of the semi-nomadic lifestyle of its tribal protagonists. This line of reasoning considers the tradition to have been condemned to irrelevance in the face of the Islamic political and cultural sensibilities (also frequently described as Islamicate or Arabo-Persian) cultivated by post-Mongol dynasties (Barthold' 1962, 5; Sümer 1967, 363, 371–76; Lewis 1974, 9, 18; Woods 1999, 181–82). Accordingly, the tradition has been viewed as an isolated window to an otherwise inaccessible Oghuz past.

Scholars agree, however, that the cycle's Aq Qoyunlu context was layered over an original core regarding the animosities among rival Turkic factions in tenth- and eleventh-century Khwarizm and Transoxiana in Central Asia (Sümer 1967, 370–74; Reichl 2012, 687–95). Given that extensive Islamization had already taken place in these regions by this time, it is inconsistent that the origins of the tradition should be considered pre-Islamic. Any early modern listener would have surmised that the Oghuz lived several hundred years after the Prophet Muhammad based on Dede Korkut's traditionally given age of three hundred, coinciding nicely with Oghuz conversions to Islam in the tenth century (Golden 1992, 213). In fact, the theme of Islamization is an important component of the tradition—namely, that Dede Korkut facilitated the Islamization of the Oghuz via the key personage of Emen who voyaged to Mecca (Tezcan and Boeschoten 2018, 65, 254; Əsker, Şamil, and Əsker 2019, 63).

The recent discovery in Tehran of a third manuscript of the tales dating to the eighteenth century (Əsker, Şamil, and Əsker 2019), in addition to long-known oral fragments of the tradition surviving in twentieth-century Anatolia (Gökyay 1973, cdliii), further shows the hollowness of assuming the tradition's incompatibility with Islamic societies. Apart from very sporadic hints at an older, possibly pre-Islamic setting (the reference to "Becene Dogs," for instance, may recall ninth- and tenth-century Oghuz conflicts with the Turkic Pechenegs), all signs point to the tales of Dede Korkut originating, circulating, and being put to writing in exclusively Islamic contexts. Attempts to portray the tradition as pre-Islamic stem from nothing other than the unfounded belief in the incompatibility of nomadic and Turkic Inner Asia with Islam (and more precisely, an unreasonably narrow notion of what constitutes true Islamic belief, practice, and culture).

THE OGHUZ EXODUS FROM INNER ASIA

The Dede Korkut epic was the second and last of the oral traditions regarding the Oghuz, but Oghuz historical consciousness did not end with these tales. A final episode of Oghuz history, found across a range of historiographical and narrative sources nearly all written in Turkish, complements the tales of Oghuz Khan and Dede Korkut. This episode recounts a migration out of Central Asia, typically from Khorasan and with a special focus on the city of Merv, where in a series of turbulent invasions, Mongols pushed out a group of Oghuz tribal leaders who then fled to Azerbaijan and the lands of Rum.[10] This account does not constitute its own epic tradition, but appeared in longer historical works as a sidenote or preface. In fact, it was frequently detached from the earlier Oghuz corpus and stood as a

self-contained origin story in dynastic accounts and warrior-hero narratives. The difficulty of positioning the migration episode vis-à-vis other traditions has caused it to be overlooked, and its various iterations have yet to be brought together for further study.

One of its earliest iterations is found in an important strand of fifteenth-century Ottoman historiography written in Turkish. Certain histories of the Ottoman house (typically titled *Tārīḫ-i āl-i ʿOṣmān*), such as one anonymous work and the chronicle of Oruç Bey, state that the grandfather of Osman Ghazi (the founder of the Ottoman Empire) was Suleyman Shah, chief of the Oghuz people (*oghūz ṭayfasī*) and ruler of the city of Mahan in Khorasan.[11] The atrocities of the Mongol invasions forced him and his followers, who were, the story notes, already Muslims, to flee westward where they led a life of religious warfare (*ghazā*) in the lands of Rum ("Recueil d'ouvrages" 4r–5v; Oruç Bey 1973, 20). Interestingly, the anonymous history asserts that the Oghuz of Khorasan shared descent with the eighth-century Abbasid hero Abu Muslim, showing how early Ottoman narratives experimented in a wide-ranging legendary repertoire. Other histories, such as a work written by one "Ruhi," mention a similar narrative in passing (1989–1992, 375).

An even more elaborate early rendition of the Oghuz migration is found in the *Jām-e Jam-āyīn*, the chronicle by Tabrizi author Ḥasan Bayati commissioned by the Ottoman Prince Cem in 1481 (Atsız 1949, 378–400). Remarkably, this text offers a genealogy based loosely on Rashid al-Din's Oghuz Khan lineage but interwoven and annotated with a wide range of oral traditions concerning the history of the world from biblical times until the Ottoman period (Bayati brushes past Oghuz Khan himself, noting that his story is already quite well known from the *Oghūznāme*). The source includes the most detailed account of any Ottoman source regarding how Oghuz ancestors came to rule over the city of Mahan, as well as their relationship with a variety of Arab, Persian, and Turkish dynasties (Atsız 1949, 390–93).[12] The narrative emphasizes the service of the Oghuz to the Khwarizmshah dynasty in Iran and Central Asia before recounting how Mongol depredations forced Kizil Bugha (four generations before Osman) to leave Iran first for Azerbaijan and then the city of Ahlat on Lake Van.

These early Ottoman accounts indicate the wide circulation of a Khorasan-to-Rum narrative in the fifteenth century, demonstrating that it was not merely a literary trope, but rather an account elaborated in a variety of ways and in reasonable detail. Other important Ottoman historians such as Şükrullah and Karamani Mehmet Pasha also mention the Mongol invasions and a flight from Iran or Ilkhanid lands as the starting point of Ottoman history, although usually only giving it the briefest of mentions. A similar pattern is found in the hagiographic literature of the period, where oral and written narratives have figures such as Ilyas Baba and Hacı Bektash Veli fleeing Khorasan for the lands of the Rum in the wake of the Mongol invasions. In the sixteenth century, these narratives mostly faded out of Ottoman official discourse, where more weight was given to the already preponderant strategy of anchoring the early history of the empire in the political context of the Seljuqs of Rum (Yınanç 1979, 334; Tezcan 2013, 394–95).[13]

But the migration narrative continued to surface in a range of sources, attesting to its oral circulation, perhaps in former Aq Qoyunlu lands in particular. Bayburtlu Osman's enigmatic late sixteenth-century Ottoman chronicle, *Tevārīh-i cedīd-i*

mir'āt-i cihān, which still associates the "Oghuz nation" primarily with Bayandur Khan and the descendants of the Aq Qoyunlu, reproduces two parallel migration stories from Rum to Khorasan, the first for Oghuz-Bayandur migrants of the Aq Qoyunlu and the second for the ancestors of the Ottoman dynasty:

> Osman Gazi's father was Ertughrul and his grandfather Suleyman Shah, who fled the land of Turkistan after the lawless interregnum of Changiz Khan and came, conquering and subduing the lands of Khorasan and Iraq. From there they went to Ahlat and Adilcavaz and founded a settlement for themselves. Because of this discord, they did not take up residence there and instead went with four hundred families and fifty thousand warriors to Rum.
>
> (Atsız 1961, 288–92)

A similar example from the same period is the *Sharafnāme* of the Kurdish official Sharaf Ḳhan Bidlisi (circa 1600). Also a product of the culture of the Ottoman-Safavid borderlands, this text closely follows Bayburtlu Osman's narrative and specifically names the city of Merv in Khorasan (which he calls "Mahan-e Marv") as the homeland of Ottoman forebears. As in Ḥasan Bayati's account, Sharaf Khan shows them to have been in the service of the Khwarizmshahs (Bidlisi 1860, 2:8). This text recounts in some detail the cruelty of the Mongols in Iran and Khorasan.

Roughly a century later, the Ottoman traveler Evliya Çelebi's (died 1682) recounting of Azerbaijan and the Ottoman-Safavid borderlands shows that the narrative had maintained its currency. This version, which Evliya reformulates on several occasions, is striking for its emphasis on the bond between the Ottomans and Aq Qoyunlu ancestors. On the latter, Evliya writes:

> They accepted Islam [upon receiving] the letter of [the Umayyid Caliph] Abdülmelik while they were still a Tatar people. Eventually, owing to the hardship wrought by the Hulagu Tatars [i.e., the Mongols] who had not accepted Islam, [the Aq Qoyunlu] ultimately left the land of Māhān in Transoxiana with the ancestors of the Ottomans and with the Danishmendids and the Chobanids. They settled in the land of Azerbaijan and ruled over the city of Ahlat, Erzurum, Diyarbakır, Irak, and Fars. There are nine of them in total. They are called *bey*, *bay*, or *shah*, and Sultan Uzun Hasan, the Bayındır Shah, is one of them. They are also close relatives to the Ottoman house.
>
> (2006, 4:99)

On at least three occasions, his account specifies Bayandur Khan as the great uncle (i.e., the brother of the grandfather) of Ertughrul, the founder of the Ottoman dynasty, although he does not make clear whether or not this Bayandur Khan corresponds to that of Aq Qoyunlu royal lineage (2006, 4:94, 4:98, 4:99). Not only does Evliya blur the lines between the Ottoman and Aq Qoyunlu houses, but also he depicts the Seljuqs of Rum as the weakened remnants of an extinguished line rather than conferrers of legitimacy (2006, 7:272). Evliya avoids the term "Oghuz," which he regards as saddled with connotations of rural naivete. He further describes all of the Turkish rulers of post-Mongol lands in Anatolia and Iran as "Tatars," a term conventionally used for the Mongols: "*cümle Tatardırlar*" (They are all Tatars) (2006, 4:99).

The final outcome of the written and oral traditions that Evliya was clearly attempting to negotiate is a strikingly original narrative with a pro-Aq Qoyunlu slant. His repeated assertion, as seen in the above passage, that the Turkish peoples of Central Asia converted to Islam upon invitation by letter from the Umayyad Caliph Hisham 'Abd al-Malik (ruled 724–743) recalls vignettes from Bayburtlu Osman and the Dede Korkut tradition, among other sources, which recount how the Oghuz converted to Islam in the time of the Prophet via direct correspondence or emissary. Evliya performs a similar syncing of Turco-Mongol and Islamic time in a comical account of how the Prophet sends a doctrinaire messenger named Mu'azz ibn Jabal to Changiz Khan in Islamic calendar year 61 to invite him to convert to Islam. Although the account has the Mongol ruler eventually converting, he objects vehemently to the concept of circumcision: "Was God unaware of this 'extra meat' when he created humanity?" (2006, 7:240).

Eighteenth- and nineteenth-century accounts show the migration narrative circulating in Anatolia and Iran, although the protagonists are universally described with a new label: Turkmen.[14] Only half a century after Evliya's death, the Afsharid ruler of Iran, Nader Shah (ruled 1736–1747), sent a letter to his Ottoman counterparts emphasizing the shared heritage of the Ottoman and Iranian Turks:

> In the time of Changiz Khan, my ancestor was the brother of the forefather of the Ottoman house who had earlier come to Anatolia, and when their father Suleyman Shah drowned, my ancestor went to Iran. By dint of this, I bear proximity to the Ottoman sultans via relations of descent.
>
> (Şem'dani-zade 1976, 60)

Another version of the letter includes the formula that "the leaders of the Turkmen tribes, who had left the land of Tūrān[15] and migrated to Iran and Anatolia, were all of one stock and one lineage" (Koca Rağıp Paşa 2003, 25). Nader presents a more synthetic version now shorn of any recognizable Aq Qoyunlu elements and following the Ottoman-Safavid binary of Anatolia and Iran. Still, the narrative maintains the key feature of a Mongol-era dispersion of a collection of Central Asian ancestors of closely related lineage and shows the persistent significance of the figures of Ertughrul and Suleyman Shah.

The nineteenth century brought variations on the theme of Mongol-era Turkmen migration and showed its longevity in the oral realm and outside of the Ottoman sphere. The introduction to an anonymous history of the Ayrumlu tribe of northwestern Iran from the late nineteenth century states:

> According to the judgment of historical chronicles and the accounts of the *Ayrumlū* elders, the *Ayrumlū* tribe is of the Turkmen people. The Changizid Hulagu Khan relocated them and had them reside in greater Syria...the sovereign and son-in-law [of Changiz], Timur, did not think it expedient that an ancient Iranian tribe be in the lands of Rūm, [and so] he forced them to migrate and brought them to Yerevan.
>
> (Mohammad n.d., IV)

Here, the theme of Changizid migration is layered over with a story of forced displacement during the Timurid period, events from roughly half a millennium prior.

Like Nader Shah's account, this episode suggests the phasing out of an Islamization narrative and perhaps an increased blurriness regarding Central Asian origins, although the formulation "ancient Iranian tribe" is compatible with the Khorasan narrative. This passage echoes Evliya's references to Hulagu Khan and suggests his enduring importance in historical memory not as the destroyer of the Caliphate but as a displacer of Turkish tribes.

A parallel to the migration narrative is found in the origin stories of the legend of the bandit-hero Koroghlu, written in prosimetric form in the nineteenth century, having circulated orally across Anatolia and Iran since the seventeenth century (Karamustafa 2020, 489–92). The two major manuscripts in the tradition, from Tabriz and northern Iran, relate somewhat divergent accounts of the protagonist's origins. The northern Iranian manuscript begins, "The origins of Koroghlu's lineage are from the Teke Turkmens...[his father] in those times was the stable-master for the King of Turkistan, that is, Sultan Murad" (Sadeq Beg 1834, IV). The injustices of the sultan soon prompt Koroghlu to flee westward to Azerbaijan, where he eventually settles in the Ottoman-Safavid borderlands. The Tabriz manuscript, on the contrary, prefaces Koroghlu westward flight differently:

> Storytellers and transmitters tell the tale thus: the Turkmen nation has been a large nation (*el*) since ancient times; they have countless well-known tribes and clans among them. There are three tribes, of which one is called the Teke, one the Yomut, and one the Celali, and these Turkmens come originally from the land of *Rūm*. Shah Ismail Safavi and Nader Shah had them migrate from *Rūm* over time and settled them between the frontiers of Herat and Merv (*Merv-e Shahjahan*) all the way to the frontiers of Mazanderan.
>
> (Azərbaycan folkloru külliyati 2010, 2:49)

Subsequently the story follows the northern Iran manuscript, with Merv and Mazandaran serving as the legendary lands of origins, although this time the protagonist's flight to Azerbaijan is attributed to the cruelty of the Safavids. Some other details, for instance, the inclusion of the Yomut, a Turkmen tribe from the Mangyshlak area, reinforce the notion of Central Asia origins. The Tabriz manuscript, then, may represent an inversion of historical memory: Koroghlu's westward voyage re-enacts the centuries-old exodus from Turkistan to Rum, while the account of the forced migrations of the Turkmen people to Khorasan reflects the later strategy deployed by Iranian rulers to repopulate and strengthen the Safavid and Afsharid frontier in Central Asia.

CONCLUSIONS ON AN EPIC HISTORICAL FRAME

It would be inaccurate to speak of a broader Oghuz epic which integrated the oral traditions of Oghuz Khan and Dede Korkut, or even of a tradition that brought only one of these with a well-elaborated version of the migration narrative. Still, it must be noted that Rashid al-Din included an extensive segment on Dede Korkut in his chronicle (2005, 66–74) and also related the migrations of the Oghuz from an initial base in Marv (2005, 95–96), although in the form of a heroic conquest in the pre-Mongol era. Very similar in structure is "The Genealogy of the Turkmens," written

by Abu'l-Ghazi Bahadur Khan in Khwarizm in 1659, known mainly as a later iteration of Rashid al-Din's genealogy but containing original material on the history of the Oghuz tribes in the time of Dede Korkut (Abu'l-Ghazi 1996, 207–18). Abu'l-Ghazi also recounts the dispersal of the Oghuz "in all directions" from Transoxiana and Khwarizm, prompted by internal conflict in the pre-Mongol era (Abu'l- Ghazi 1996, 199–203). Both of these accounts of the Oghuz dispersion are distinct from the westward exodus narrative though, suggesting that the latter represents a consolidation of several historical layers including the scattering of the Oghuz tribes of Transoxiana in the eleventh century, as hinted by Woods (1999, 27). Only later would these migrations be codified as a single, Mongol-era event.

Other texts also permit us to imagine a more integral Oghuz historical consciousness, albeit a hazy one. Rashid al-Din's Mamluk contemporary Ibn al-Dawadari describes Oghuz Khan and elements of the Dede Korkut stories as both belonging to the *Oghūznāme*, a book brought into Mamluk realms after "the emergence of the Tatars from their lands" (*khurūj al-tātār min bilādihim*) (Graf 1990, 51, 55–56), referring to Turkish speakers. In the sixteenth century, the three epic phases were brought together again in a cursory fashion and inserted into the lineage-oriented account of Hasan Bayati (Atsız 1949, 378–400).

It may be that the Mongol period was a unique historical moment in which stories of Oghuz Khan and Dede Korkut were merged into a common oral and written tradition, and that this tradition was best preserved in Aq Qoyunlu realms where the Oghuz migration narrative was also commonly told. At the very least, these sources point to a long-term engagement with a cast of legendary Oghuz characters and events which could be brought together as needed according to political and historical circumstances.

The migration narrative, elaborated in the Ottoman and Aq Qoyunlu contexts, was eventually incorporated into a post-Oghuz conception of the past, after the Oghuz identity lost its appeal as a feature of historical memory. Judging by when the narrative was rebranded as a triumphant Turkmen arrival into Rum and Iran, this change must have taken place by the seventeenth century. By then, Turkmen tribes in Ottoman and Safavid lands had become increasingly peripheral to the structures of early modern empires, namely, large standing armies and stricter cash-based tax regimes. It is therefore unsurprising that the narrative featured in popular traditions that challenged imperial power, as we find in the Köroğlu epic. The Oghuz, who had once ruled a universal empire, became the Turkmen opponents of the political structures that they had helped to construct.

The historical significance of the migration story should be further explored, as the themes of trauma and displacement among Turkmen tribes may illuminate aspects of Anatolian and Iranian history. What impact did such historical memory have, for instance, on the early Safavid movement, where it may have fueled a sense of injustice and a desire for the restitution of an imagined order of times past? Did the circulation of such narratives play a role in sixteenth-century Turkmen migrations from Anatolia to Iran, or affect the historical sensibilities of Turkmen tribes in the Ottoman-Safavid borderlands? How can we understand their lasting connection, material or imagined, to Khorasan and Inner Asia?

On the whole, the political value and function of Oghuz epic narratives reflect the increasing growth of the early modern Eurasian state vis-à-vis its often-Turkic tribal

military base. The narratives of Oghuz Khan, which likely originated in a much older and pre-Islamic Inner Asian context, were well suited to the exigencies of the Mongol universal empire, and later became a fixture of the Persianate historiography of Turkic dynasties who drew upon the Mongol legacy. The Dede Korkut tradition navigated the Islamic frontier of Inner Asia, later superimposed onto the frontiers of Rum, flourishing in the fragmented post-Mongol landscape but rarely taken up by early modern dynasties. The consolidation of the large-scale, bureaucratic Eurasian states eventually brought about the need for new storytelling traditions in the oral realm. In this transition, the tribal exodus out of Eurasia became codified as one of the final acts of Oghuz history.

NOTES

1 Oghuz Turks are the largest sub-group of Turkic peoples. In this chapter, "Turkic" indicates a broader and more inclusive category, whereas "Turkish" more narrowly applies to the Oghuz Turks. In the second millennium CE, the Oghuz mainly lived in the Middle East and western swathes of Inner Asia around modern Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, and Turkmenistan, and today are chiefly in the Balkans, Turkey, the Caucasus, Syria, Iraq, Iran, and Turkmenistan. Oghuz is spelled "Oğuz" in western Turkish.

2 He is called "Oghuz Kagan" in eastern Turkic. I use Khan for consistency.

3 See, for example, Reichl (2011), where he writes that in the Turkish epic, "Two areas of foreign influence can be distinguished, the Iranian and the Arabian" (683).

4 Space does not permit for this study to delve into the origins of Oghuz epic traditions, which surely pre-date the Mongol period.

5 See Binbaş (2010) for a thorough overview of the stories of Oghuz Khan.

6 A Persian hero in the *Shāhnāmeh*.

7 The most well-known example is the Qarakhanid dynasty of Transoxiana (999–1211), called "Āl-i Afrāsiyāb" in sources from the period (Golden 1994, 214).

8 The Soviet folklorist Korogli also suggests that the two epic traditions were already intertwined, pointing to a range of Turkic elements and characters in the *Shāhnāmeh*, including Qarakhan (son of Afrasiyab) and Krukhan (referenced twice as a relation of Afrasiyab) (1983, 117–59).

9 This name is typically rendered "Bayındır" in modern Turkish. I opt for "Bayandur" to adhere to the spelling in the sources of the period at hand and for consistency.

10 Rum, or Rome, was the nearly universal term in the pre-modern Islamic world for the former Byzantine lands of Anatolia.

11 Others could be added to this list; for instance, the *Ṣelātīn-nāme* of a historian named Kemal from the time of Bayezid II, although I was not able to verify its details based on Yınanç (1978, 175). The *Düstūrnāme* by Enveri (composed 1465) likely also drew upon this model.

12 Mahan (spelled either *māhān* or *māḥān*) was clearly a narrative element that had long circulated in the oral tradition, as the author confuses or blends the town in Khorasan with another of the same name either in the vicinity of Kerman or Hamadan.

13 We are likely missing fifteenth-century sources, which would have established a clearer link between Oghuz Khan narratives, *The Book of Dede Korkut*, and Oghuz migration stories, as deduced by Woods (1999, 176–77).

14 This term, coined as early as the eleventh century, refers to Islamized Turkish tribes but retains connotations of unruliness and uncouthness (Karamustafa 2020).

15 Turan was a conventional term for Inner Asia.

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